of saleable steel'. In the AGM of the following year, Ratan unveiled his plan to strategically disperse the company's production centres. He also announced that the various associated companies of the steel major were 'being restructured and re-grouped in order to make them collectively stronger and more viable'. With this, Ratan kickstarted the fourth modernization phase aimed at doubling the capacity of the hot strip mill from 1 MT to 2 MT.

The next year, in 1996, he announced the closure of outdated facilities at Jamshedpur. Ratan underlined the 'strength of Tata Steel's fundamentals, the spirit of winning and the impressive transition' that it had achieved in the last couple of years. Buoyed, he said that it would strengthen the company to 'face its future challenges' and 'continue to be the first name and the last word in steel'.

During the year, as a part of the geographical expansion, the company 'sanctioned Rs 1,800 crores for the establishment of the first stage of the cold rolling mill (CRM)' at Gopalpur, Odisha. In addition, TISCO also looked at collaborations as a route to enhance the quality of its products and entered into a 50:50 JV agreement with US-based Ryerson Steel Industries, Inc. The venture, called Tata-Ryerson Limited (now known as TSDPL), commenced operations in Jamshedpur and Pune and later expanded to Delhi, Gopalpur and Hosur. TISCO also 'entered into technical tie-ups with two German companies', Thyssenkrupp and Lurgi Metallurgie.

As a part of the technological upgradation programme emphasized by Ratan, the company embraced stamp-charged coke-making technology and soon became the world's largest producer of this kind of coke in 1998. It was a significant step towards cost reduction as it allowed use of medium cooking coal from the company's own collieries. Simultaneously, Ratan moved for the overall modernization of its processes and 'entered into an agreement with the National Securities Depository Ltd, for dematerialising its shares'. In the process, it became the 'first Tata group company to enter the depository'.

One of Ratan's new initiatives was to hive off TISCO's non-core business activities—an approach that again had its roots in the 1983 Strategic Plan. Taking the plan forward, in 1998 the company sold its cement unit to Lafarge SA of France in what was 'considered to be the third largest deal in Indian corporate history'. The following year, TISCO pulled